

JSS 2 NIGERIAN HISTORY – FIRST TERM

TOPIC 3: MILITARY RULE IN NIGERIA I – CAUSES OF THE JANUARY 1966 COUP

1. The Coup of 15 January 1966

On 15 January 1966, a group of young army officers led a coup. Several political leaders were killed, including the Prime Minister Tafawa Balewa, the Premier of the North Sir Ahmadu Bello, and the Premier of the West Chief S.L. Akintola. Major-General Johnson Aguiyi-Ironsi eventually took over as Head of State.

2. Causes of the Coup

- Political crisis and breakdown of law and order, especially in the Western Region after disputed elections.
- Corruption and abuse of power by some politicians.
- Ethnic and regional tensions and fear of domination.
- Dissatisfaction within the army over promotions and political interference.
- Desire by the plotters to end what they saw as a corrupt and divided civilian system.

3. Immediate Outcome

The civilian First Republic ended. Aguiyi-Ironsi's military government suspended the constitution, banned political parties and began to rule by decree. The coup itself was controversial because of the pattern of killings and the ethnic interpretations that followed.

4. Summary

The January 1966 coup was driven by political crisis, corruption and regional tensions. It ended the First Republic and introduced military rule under Aguiyi-Ironsi.

End of Topic 3